

Take frequent backups: Some plugins work independently of your blog's content and files, just adding a little something special to the page. Others require modification of content and files, including changes to your database. Before installing any plugin that will make dramatic changes, backup your database and files.

5.4 Developing your own plugins

Once you start using WordPress Plugins, you sometimes wonder how you ever got along without them. If you have knowledge of PHP, you can develop your own plugins, but detailed instructions are beyond the scope of this book.

5.5 Most popular Wordpress plugins

1. All in One SEO Pack - <http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/all-in-one-seo-pack/>

It automatically optimises your WordPress blog for search engines: page titles, meta tags, keywords, and descriptions. This plugin allows you to configure them for either your entire blog or on a post by post basis.

2. Google Analytics for WordPress - <http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/google-analytics-for-wordpress/>

The Google Analytics for WordPress plugin allows you to track your blog easily. It adds the asynchronous tracking code for Google Analytics and automatically tracks and segments all outbound links from within posts, comment author links, links within comments, blogroll links and downloads. It'll add custom variables while tracking to show you page views per author, post type, category or publication year. It'll also allow you to track AdSense clicks, add extra search engines, and even ignore certain user levels.

3. Contact Form 7 - <http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/contact-form-7/>

Contact Form 7 can manage multiple contact forms, plus you can customise the form and the mail contents flexibly with simple markup. The form supports Ajax-powered submitting, captcha, and Akismet spam filtering.

4. Akismet - <http://wordpress.org/extend/plugins/akismet/>

Akismet checks your comments against the Akismet web service to see if they look like spam or not and lets you review the spam it catches under your blog's "Comments" admin screen.